# Jay Stewart

**Product engineer.** I find out what users need, then ship it with coding agents.

Available now for remote contract work

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## PROFILE

Product engineer who finds out what users need, then ships it with coding agents. Since March 2026 I have shipped three products solo: SpiralClass, a teacher platform in production that takes real payments through Stripe Connect; WantToJoin, which went from reading a hostel's guest chat to a live pilot there in three days; and Beckon, an end-to-end encrypted inbox for terminal agents, live since October 2026. Before that I spent eight years on e-commerce backends, on systems that hold other people's money. Available for contract work with early-stage startups: MVPs, first versions and product engineering.

## EXPERIENCE

### Founder & Product Engineer · Independent

Mar 2026 – now

**SpiralClass** `live · real payments` Scheduling, payments and video for independent teachers, built and run solo. In production with a teacher and her eight students.

- TypeScript end to end: Next.js 16, Postgres through Prisma (82 models), Inngest background jobs, self-hosted LiveKit video, about 870 test files.
- Moved payments to Stripe Connect direct charges on Accounts v2, so the teacher is merchant of record and the platform never holds funds. Added Wise as a second rail, reconciled through its API.
- Release engineering: a merge gate tied to the exact commit pushed, the same definition of green locally and in CI, coverage floors, migration drift checks and a documented database rollback.
- Cut CI spend by tracing about 744 billable minutes a month to one workflow, without making any step manual.

**WantToJoin** `pilot · one hostel` One page per hostel with tonight's plans, RSVPs and a live meeting pin.

- Read 2,800 messages from five months of a hostel's guest WhatsApp group before writing code. The finding changed the product: build for the hostel's social hosts, not the guests, with the hostel as the buyer.
- Reviewed the competition (Hostelworld Linkups, SocialStay) and built only what they don't offer: no app to download, a live meeting pin, and a minimum headcount with a deadline.
- From research to a live pilot in three days; 129 commits on Cloudflare Workers and D1, with PostHog analytics. Every user-facing change tested in a real browser at phone width.
- An AI post writer drafts each post in English and Spanish with Claude Haiku, checked in code: all 50 eval drafts pass, at about $0.0003 a post.

**Beckon** `live · open source` A remote inbox for terminal agents: approve or deny a waiting Claude Code session or build from your phone's lock screen. Live since October 2026, no outside users yet. Source: github.com/jaystewartuk/beckon.

- Found the problem in recurring Hacker News threads, then wrote the spec first: user flows, a security model, acceptance criteria and explicit non-goals.
- End-to-end encrypted. Devices pair by comparing a six-word safety code; the helper types a response only after checking its signature, the trusted device, the record revision and the offered option.
- A Go helper that wraps commands in a pseudo-terminal, a Next.js, WebSocket and Postgres service, and an installable web app with push notifications.
- Moved production off Cloud Run to one hardened VM: key-only SSH, read-only containers, a least-privilege database user, nightly encrypted offsite backups with a rehearsed restore, and a dead man's switch on monitoring.

**Career break** Mar 2020 – Mar 2026

A planned break after eight years in e-commerce, travelling on savings. Back in March 2026 because coding agents changed what one person can ship.

**Backend Engineer** · G&V | Venture Brands Agency (contract) · Bristol Jul 2017 – Mar 2020

- High-traffic e-commerce platforms, including Dyson's store. Custom backend modules for stores handling transactions and customer data at scale.
- Fixed production issues where an outage meant lost orders, working with client engineering teams against fixed launch dates.

**Backend Engineer** · Thrive Chiropractic (contract, remote) Aug 2016 – Mar 2020

- Designed and built a booking and payment platform from scratch, and ran it for nearly four years: real-time scheduling, secure payments, and the reporting the practice used to make decisions.

**Backend Engineer** · Folk Digital · Bournemouth Jul 2014 – Aug 2016

- Backend features and third-party integrations for performance-sensitive e-commerce clients.

**Backend Engineer** · C3 Media · Bristol Jul 2012 – Jul 2014

- Went from junior PHP developer to building and maintaining full e-commerce systems on my own.

## HOW I WORK

- **I start with users.** I talk to them in person, read their real conversations, and change the plan when the evidence points somewhere else.
- **Experiments have a stopping rule.** A hypothesis, what gets built, what gets measured and when to stop are written down before the code.
- **Agents write a lot of the code, and I own the result.** Pull requests, CI gates and testing in a real browser, so quality doesn't depend on a reviewer happening to notice a problem.

## SKILLS

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| **Product** | User interviews, analysing chat and usage data, competitor research, experiment design, pilots with real customers |
| **Building with agents** | Claude Code, parallel agent sessions in git worktrees, CLAUDE.md conventions, evals, CI gates and browser testing to verify agent output |
| **Stack** | TypeScript, Node, Next.js, React, Postgres, Prisma, Go, Cloudflare Workers and D1, Inngest, LiveKit, WebSockets; PHP and Magento before 2020 |
| **Payments** | Stripe Connect (direct charges, Accounts v2), Wise reconciliation, Mercado Pago (an earlier version) |
| **Operations** | GitHub Actions, Docker, Google Cloud Run, a hardened Hetzner VM, encrypted offsite backups, uptime and heartbeat monitoring, Sentry, PostHog |
| **Languages** | English (native), Spanish (conversational) |